

FIELD NOTE · 2026 · TRUST & SAFETY · COMMUNITY OPS

Watching Is Not Proving

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Ban evasion looks simple from the outside. Someone gets banned, comes back under a different account, and you catch them. In practice, the catching is the part you can rarely prove.

I'm writing this from memory, so I'm leaving out details I can't confirm. What I do remember is how the case built up.

A user had been banned. Later, someone joined from a different account, and something about how that person talked about the earlier events didn't sit right. People who get banned rarely tell those around them the real reason. They tend to tell a version where they were right, and the details get too specific or start to bend. That alone proves nothing. I treated it as a reason to keep looking, not as a conclusion.

So we watched. Some of the helpers spoke about the banned user directly. These weren't people who had joined recently. They were players who had been in the community for years, and several of them knew him well enough to speak with confidence, including one or two of the most senior moderators. I didn't know him myself, but the people around me did. A few complaints came in as well. So we asked around: people who knew him, and people who simply didn't like him. That second group matters, and it's also a risk. Someone with a grudge is not a neutral source. That is a reason to weigh what they say carefully, not to ignore it.

Only after those pieces pointed the same direction did we act. We put together the evidence, including the account ID and many photos, and banned the account for ban evasion.

Do I know it was the same person? I can say the sources agreed, and that the people who knew him best were among them. These sources all came from the same community, so I wouldn't call them independent in a strict sense. I can't say I proved it from data. The logs alone would never have gotten us there.

That's the line I try to hold. A signal is a reason to look closer, not a reason to decide. The ban came from several separate sources agreeing, not from any one of them.

Suggested citation: Taghiev, T. "Watching Is Not Proving." Field Note, 2026.

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